Parshat Vayeleich – Living Beyond the Self

Parshat Vayeleich is remarkable not only for its depth, but for its brevity. At only thirty pesukim, it is the shortest parsha in the Torah. If not combined with Nitzavim, it still stands alone — and yet, within this tiny frame, Moshe Rabbeinu delivers messages that carry through eternity.

The very fact that it's so short is itself meaningful. Chazal teach (Megillah 21a) that the minimum halachic length of an aliyah is three pesukim. On average, each aliyah in Vayeleich barely passes that threshold. It's as if the Torah is saying: even when only the minimum words are spoken, the eternal truths of Torah can fill our world with meaning.

And how fitting that we read this parsha on **Shabbat Shuvah**, in the middle of the **Aseret Yemei Teshuvah** — the holiest stretch of the year, standing between Rosh Hashanah and Yom Kippur. A short parsha, a few words, but packed with enormous weight.

Moshe's Last Day

The parsha begins with Moshe's startling declaration:
"בֶּן מֵאָה וְעֶשְׂרִים שָׁנָה אָנֹכִי הַיּוֹם, לֹא אוּכַל עוֹד לָצֵאת וְלָבוֹא"
— *"I am 120 years old today; I can no longer go out and come in"* (Devarim 31:2).

Rashi notes: *his strength had not diminished* (cf. Devarim 34:7), but his leadership had reached its destined conclusion. This was not a moment of weakness, but of transition.

Think about it: most people, if they somehow knew this was their last day, would spend it on themselves. They might try to cram in last pleasures, adventures, or urgent regrets. But Moshe does none of this. His last day is spent as his life was spent — speaking to Am Yisrael, strengthening them, warning them of dangers ahead, and ensuring the Torah will never be forgotten.

This is the sign of someone who truly lives **beyond self**. He has no fear for himself, no regrets, no scrambling. He trusts that his own destiny is in Hashem's hands. What remains is his responsibility and love for Am Yisrael.

The Warning and the Hope

As in the previous parshiyot, Moshe again warns the people that when they enter the Land, they will falter, they will stumble, they will turn after foreign gods. But notice his tone: it is not just rebuke (*tochacha*), it is awareness, a father's warning born of love. He is telling them what will happen so that when it happens, they will know how to return.

And immediately, Moshe anchors them with tools of return: the mitzvah of **Hakhel**.

Hakhel – Carrying Torah Into Life

In the fourth aliyah (Devarim 31:10–13), Moshe commands that once every seven years, in the year after Shemitah, the entire nation must gather in Yerushalayim to hear the king read from Sefer Devarim.

The timing is brilliant. After a full year of Shemitah — a year when fields lie fallow and people, hopefully, immerse in Torah and family — the natural human drive is to rush back to work, to "catch up" on everything left undone. Precisely then, the Torah commands: stop. Come together, men, women, children, even the babies. Hear again the core words of Torah. Bring them with you into the fields, into the markets, into ordinary life.

Hakhel ensures that Torah is not left in the Beit Midrash, but carried into the rhythm of daily living. It is the blueprint for turning inspiration into action.

Strengthening Yehoshua

Moshe then turns to Yehoshua:
"חֲזַק וֶאֱמָץ" — *"Be strong and courageous"* (Devarim 31:7).

This is more than encouragement. It is the handover of leadership, the passing of flame. Moshe knows his influence in this world is coming to an end, so his focus is on empowering the next generation. Again, we see that his concern is never about himself. It is always about the people, the Torah, and Hashem's will moving forward.

The Beinoni – Humility That Lives On

This selflessness echoes in the famous Gemara (Berachot 61b), quoted in the very opening of **Tanya**:

> **אמר רבה: לדידי, כי האי בינוני אנא.**
> *Rabbah said: As for me, I am a beinoni.*

To which Abaye exclaimed in shock:

> **אמר ליה אביי: לא שביק מר חיי לכל בריה!**
> *Abaye said: Master, if you are a beinoni, you leave no life for any creature!*

How could Rabbah, one of the greatest sages, consider himself a mere *beinoni* — a "middle person"? The Alter Rebbe explains: the beinoni of Tanya is not someone half-meritorious and half-sinful. Rather, he is one who still experiences temptation, but never allows it to dominate thought, speech, or action.

Rabbah's greatness lay in his humility, in being so removed from self that he never assumed the title *tzaddik*. His eternal life came from this very selflessness. As Chazal say:
צדיקים במיתתן קרויים חיים — *The righteous, even in death, are called alive* (Berachot 18a).

When one lives beyond the self, one's name and Torah live on forever.

Leaders and Legacy

This is true of Moshe, whose name and Torah endure beyond any human in history. It is true of Yehoshua, who absorbed and carried Moshe's mission forward. It is true of countless Tannaim and Amoraim, whose words of Torah remain alive in every Beit Midrash.

It is even true in the negative sense: the names of wicked leaders endure too — but only as warnings, like poison labels marked with skull and crossbones. Their legacy is emptiness, preserved only so we avoid repeating their mistakes.

But those who live aligned with Hashem, those who give themselves for Torah and for the good of Am Yisrael, they live on in blessing. Their legacy is Torah itself.

Yom Kippur – The Happiest Day

And this is exactly the message of Yom Kippur. We declare:
"היום הרת עולם, היום יעמיד במשפט כל יצורי עולמים"
— *Today the world was created; today all creatures stand in judgment.*

Judgment is fearful, but it is also filled with joy. The Gemara (Ta'anit 26b) calls Yom Kippur one of the two happiest days of the year. How so? On Yom Kippur we abstain from food, drink, comforts — we dress in white, like angels. Yet it is joyous because, in that state, we experience what it means to live entirely for Hashem.

Even the *din* (judgment) itself becomes a source of simcha, because we know that Hashem's ratzon is the truest good. Like Moshe, like Rabbah, like the beinoni, when our will aligns with Hashem's will, we live beyond fear. We live beyond self.

The Takeaway

Parshat Vayeleich is short in words, but endless in meaning.

Moshe spends his last day not on himself, but on Am Yisrael. He ensures their future, empowers their leader, and gives them mitzvot that will carry them forward. Rabbah, in the Gemara, models the same humility — never resting on his greatness, but living as if the struggle is always before him.

And Yom Kippur crowns the lesson: when our lives are lived for Hashem, when our ratzon is His ratzon, then even the day of judgment becomes a day of joy. We need not fear the end, because our Torah, our influence, our legacy lives on.

This is the gift of Moshe's last words: a life lived for Hashem is a life that never truly ends.